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B

Baal

t285: Baal

Baal was the most important male god that the Canaanite people worshiped before the Israelites conquered Canaan, the land God had promised them. People sometimes used the name "Baal" to talk about one specific god in one place. At other times, people used the word that meant "many Baals" to refer to all the male false gods in Canaan.

In the original language, the name Baal literally means a lord, master, or husband—someone who controls or has authority over someone or something. The Canaanites believed that Baal controlled the wind and rain, caused plants to grow, and also gave people children. So people made sacrifices of animals and grain to Baal, and sometimes also had sexual relations with each other as part of their worship of Baal.

Asherah was a false goddess whom the Canaanites also worshiped. Asherah was one of Baal's partners, and people often talked about and worshiped Baal and Asherah together. As part of their worship of Asherah, people often made a wooden pole, sometimes carved images on it, and set it upright in the ground to honor Asherah.

Baal

Audio Content
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baptism

To **baptize** someone, or something, means to immerse it in water to wash it. It comes from the Greek word "baptizo."

The word has a special religious meaning. In the Old Testament, Jewish priests would baptize themselves before they would do their work in the temple of God. This made them "clean" so that they were fit to approach God.

When people who were not Jewish wanted to follow God, they could be baptized. After that, they would be accepted as part of God's people. We do not hear about this custom in the Old Testament, but we know about it from other books from the history of the Jews.

When John the baptizer came, he did something new by telling all the people that they should take baptism. Being born as a Jew wasn't enough to be part of God's people! All people needed to repent, to say sorry for the bad things that they had done. They needed to turn away from their old life, and to start a new way of living. They should start obeying God!

Just before Jesus went back to heaven, he told his disciples to go and tell people everywhere that Jesus has all authority. Jesus told them to make all people Jesus's disciples, and to baptize them in the name of the father, the son, and the Holy Spirit.

And so, from that time onwards, we see that as soon as people began to believe in Jesus they took baptism. This baptism was a sign of their repentance and need for forgiveness. But it was also a sign that they now belonged to Jesus and wanted to follow him.

Paul, in his letters, explains that when we take baptism it is as if we die and become alive again. We die by going under in the water, and become alive again by coming up out of the water. This is a symbol showing that our old life is dead. We now have a new life because we belong to Jesus. Jesus died for us, and became alive again. When we take baptism, we accept that Jesus died in our place, and that we are new people because God has forgiven us. Just as water cleanses our bodies from dirt, Jesus has "cleansed" us from our sins. Now we are fit to approach God!

The ritual of baptism was something that only needed to be done once.

When you are translating baptism, be careful about the following things:

The word baptism, and to baptize someone, can be difficult to translate. Many people use a word that sounds like the Greek word "baptizo." New believers will have to slowly learn what this word means. You can also use a term that would be more meaningful for the people in your language group. If people in your community have a form of ritual bathing, this word might be helpful in translating baptism. However, be sure you understand the meaning of the ritual in your community, and think about the difference between the meaning of that ritual and baptism in the Bible. You may need to explain how baptism in the Bible is different from the ritual in your community.

You can also use a word that sounds like "baptizo," but then add a small phrase to give more explanation about its meaning.

baptism

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basket

People use a **basket** to carry or store things. People make baskets by weaving together thin sticks, stems of plants, or reeds. A reed is a plant that grows in the water.

Some baskets were small and people carried them on their back. People used these baskets for carrying food. Other baskets were bigger, and two people might be needed to carry them when they were full. For example, fishermen used these baskets to collect the fish that they caught and to take it to the market.

basket

Audio Content
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belief

To believe and to have faith mean the same thing.

If you believe in someone, you believe that what that person says about himself is true. You then trust that person and are committed to do what that person tells you to do.

Abraham believed that God spoke the truth when he promised that Abraham would have many descendants, even though Abraham was already old and did not have even one child. Abraham trusted that God would fulfill his promise, even though it seemed impossible.

If you believe in God, you accept that God exists and that what God says in the Bible is true. You trust that God will fulfill all his promises, even when it seems impossible. As a result, you are committed to obey everything that God wants you to do.

When you believe in Jesus, you believe that Jesus is indeed the son of God. You trust that Jesus has indeed died for your sins, and that God has forgiven and accepted you. As a result, you are committed to do everything that Jesus has commanded.

The Bible sometimes says that people should "believe in Jesus's name." This means the same thing as to believe in Jesus.

Someone who has great faith or belief, trusts God-or Jesus-very much.

When you are translating the word "believe," be careful about the following things:

In some languages, the word "believe" can sound as if someone only hopes that something is true, but they are not sure. This is not the right meaning. Therefore, sometimes it can be better to use a word that means "trust." Pause here and do the following activity as a group: Ask one person to volunteer to be the person who has to trust, or have faith. That person should stand with their back to a group of at least 5 people, if you have that many people. Those five people should stand right behind the volunteer. They should be capable and willing to catch the volunteer. Ask the volunteer to fall back into the arms of the group of people. Ask the volunteer: Did you hesitate to do that? How do you feel as you decide whether or not to fall back into the arms of the group?

Maybe the volunteer chooses to not actually fall back, even though the volunteer knows that the volunteer's friends will catch them. Ask the group: How does the group feel when the volunteer chooses to not fall back into their arms?

Maybe the volunteer chooses to fall back into the group's arms. How does the volunteer feel after the group catches him? How does the group feel, knowing that the person has trusted them? This is an example of having faith, or trusting. You do not trust unless you really fall back into the arms of the group. You may say that you trust them, but true trust does not happen until you fall. Trusting means to act on what you say. Pause the recording here.

belief

Audio Content
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believer

After Pentecost, the people who followed Jesus were also called **believers**. A believer is a person who has chosen to believe the good news about Jesus and to trust in Jesus and follow him as their Lord, or master. In Acts, people often call this group of people "brothers," or "brothers and sisters," because believers are like members of the same family with God as their father. Some Bible translations translate "brothers" as "believers."

believer

Audio Content
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Bethlehem

Bethlehem is the birthplace of Jesus.

Bethlehem was a small village in Israel. The name Bethlehem means "house of bread." In the Old Testament, the events in the book of Ruth took place in

Bethlehem. Ruth was a Moabite woman, so she was not an Israelite. Ruth's first husband had died, so Ruth came to live in Bethlehem with her Israelite mother-in-law. Later, Ruth married an Israelite man from Bethlehem. The great grandson of Ruth and her Israelite husband was David, who would later become the most beloved king of Israel.

Because king David was born in Bethlehem, Bethlehem is also called the city of David.

God later said through the prophet Micah that another very important ruler would be born in Bethlehem. Therefore the Jews were expecting that the Messiah, the special King and Savior that God had promised to send, would be born in Bethlehem.

God fulfilled this promise when Jesus was born in Bethlehem.

Bethlehem was a few kilometers away from Jerusalem, which was the most important city for the Jews.

Bethlehem

Audio Content
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Bethsaida

Bethsaida is a village in the province of Galilee. It was probably close to the city of Capernaum, because John tells us that Jesus's disciples Andrew and Peter came from Bethsaida, but Mark tells us that they lived in Capernaum. The village was close to the Sea of Galilee, and many people in the village made their living from fishing. The name Bethsaida even means "house of fishing."

Bethsaida

Audio Content
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blasphemy

To **blaspheme** someone means to speak evil about a person, and to insult someone. A person who curses God, insults God, dishonors God, or makes God seem less powerful or important, is blaspheming God. The punishment for blasphemy was death.

blasphemy

Audio Content
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bless

When God **blesses** a person, God is doing, or promising to do, something good for that person.

When a human speaks a **blessing** over another person, they are praying that God will do good things for this other person.

When people are blessing God, it means they are worshiping God and thanking him for his goodness and his blessings.

When people are blessing something-for instance food-this means that they are thanking God for it.

When you call someone **blessed**, you mean to say that other people can congratulate that person. Other people can be glad for those people, because God has blessed them.

The opposite of a blessing is a curse. Through Moses, God told the Israelites that if they would obey God's commandments, God would bless them. But if they would disobey God, God would curse them. God will not protect those people who are cursed, and people who are cursed will not be in a good relationship with God.

bless

Audio Content
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blood

Every human and animal lives because God puts his own life breath in it. In the Old Testament, blood symbolizes this life breath. A person cannot live without blood, and so when blood drains out of a body, it is as if God's life breath is leaving the body.

In the Old Testament, God told the people that they should not eat the blood of an animal. When they ate meat, they first had to completely drain the animal of blood. By draining the blood from the animal, it was as if the people gave the life breath of the animal back to God.

Because blood, as long as it is in our bodies, represented life, losing blood represented death. Anything which is dead symbolizes how bad sin has made God's good creation. Therefore, a dead body of a human or an animal was unclean, meaning unacceptable before God, and anyone who touched such a dead body would become unclean as well.

A person who was losing blood was for this reason also unclean. Even though the person was not dead, it was as if they-symbolically-were already a little bit dead.

Therefore even a woman who was just menstruating, or a man who was discharging blood, was unclean until the bleeding was over. Anyone who touched such a person became unclean as well. In the Gospels we see a bleeding woman touching Jesus-but instead of this making Jesus unclean, Jesus made the woman clean by healing her from her sickness!

Because blood is so important for a person's life, the word is often used as picture language for "life." So, someone who killed someone has "shed blood," even if no blood has flowed.

Even though losing blood was bad and made someone unclean, blood of animals that were sacrificed to God were used to make people or things clean. Blood was an important part of the sacrifices that the Israelites made to God. When the priests brought God a sacrifice, they collected the blood of the animal that they were sacrificing. Depending on the type of ritual, the priests would sprinkle the blood on the altar, or on some specific object, or on a person. This symbolized that these objects or people were now clean. They were now suitable for serving God.

Blood was also used to make a formal agreement, called a covenant. When God made his covenant with Abraham, Abraham had to kill some animals, and therefore he shed blood. Jesus says that his, Jesus', blood is the sign of the new covenant. This means that the death of Jesus made possible a new covenant between God and people. In the Old Testament, the blood of animals made people clean. But now the blood of Jesus makes the people who believe in him clean-God forgives them and accepts them. In the Old Testament, people had to sacrifice animals again and again. But Jesus died once, and this was sufficient for all the generations of the people!

blood

Audio Content
mp3 file (2.3 MB)

boat

People build **boats** to travel across water. A boat can be very small and hold just a few people, or it can be large and hold hundreds of people. A boat can be open to the top, or it can have a roof over a part of the boat with one or several rooms inside.

People can move a boat forward by moving long sticks called oars through the water. This is called rowing. Larger boats would also have sails. A sail is a large piece of cloth that is attached to a long pole called a mast. The sail will catch the wind, and this moves the boat forward. Sailors are people who handle the boat and maneuver the sails so that the wind gives them the best speed. In the Old Testament, Jonah got on a sailboat like this when he was not willing to go to Nineveh.

Jesus and his disciples often traveled by boat across the Sea of Galilee. These were boats used by fishermen to go across the lake and to catch fish in the lake. These were rowing boats, though some boats may have had a small sail as well. These boats were just the right size to fit Jesus and his 12 disciples.

In the book of Acts, we read that Paul also traveled by boat sometimes. These boats were larger, and had sails. People traveled in these boats for longer distances. Sometimes storms made traveling by boat difficult, and a shipwreck could occur-this means that the boat would break and would sink. People could die in shipwrecks. Traveling by boat could therefore be quite dangerous.

A boat has a small, movable, piece of wood attached to it which is called a rudder. This allows the people to make the boat go in the direction that they want. James in his epistle compares our tongue to a rudder of a boat-very small, but very powerful!

You can look in the video dictionary for some pictures of different types of boats.

To help your teams understand the size of the boat that Jesus and his disciples used, try drawing in the dirt or with a piece of charcoal the shape of the boat on the ground. The boat is about eight big steps long, and three small steps wide. Now fit 13 people inside this space! Do you think that there would have been space for more people?

boat

Audio Content
mp3 file (1.8 MB)

bow

When a person **bows** down before someone else, they lower their head or the whole top of their body forward. They do this to show respect and humility. A person can also bow down by kneeling in front of a person and putting their head to the ground.

Sometimes people even stretched themselves out flat on the ground in front of a person. This is called falling at someone's feet.

bow

Audio Content
mp3 file (371 KB)

bread of the presence

The **bread of the Presence** was 12 loaves of bread that priests put on the table in the Holy Place of the tabernacle, and later, in the temple of Yahweh. Every Sabbath, the priests put 12 loaves of fresh bread on the table in the Holy Place. The priests arranged the bread in two rows of six loaves. The priests also put pure frankincense on the table with the loaves of bread. Frankincense is a resin that comes from a tree and smells very good.

After the priests put the fresh bread on the table, they could take the old bread and eat it. The Israelites did not think of this bread as a sacrifice to Yahweh, and they did not think that Yahweh ate the bread in any way. Rather, the priests obeyed Yahweh when they put the bread on the table in the Holy Place, and Yahweh provided for the priests by allowing them to eat the bread. The bread symbolized both Yahweh's presence with the Israelites and Yahweh's promise to always provide for the Israelites.

When the priests made the bread, they used two-tenths of an ephah, or two omers, of fine flour for each piece. This might have been anywhere from two to six kilograms of flour. Fine flour is grain that people have crushed into extremely small pieces, so that the flour is like powder. Fine flour was the best quality flour.

Throughout the Bible, the storytellers sometimes use different names for this bread. The storytellers might call it showbread, consecrated bread, dedicated bread, holy bread, sacred bread, the bread offering, or the bread of the pile.

bread of the presence

Audio Content
mp3 file (1.5 MB)

bronze

Bronze is a metal that people make when they heat copper and tin in a very hot fire until the two metals become a liquid and melt together. When this new metal cools, it is very hard and tough. So people would use bronze to make important items like some of the special cups, bowls, and forks for the tabernacle and temple, musical instruments, and things like spears, shields, and armor for battle.

Bronze is a golden-brown color, and people can polish bronze to make it very shiny. But bronze can also tarnish, which means that air and moisture can slowly make bronze change to a darker color and lose its shine.

bronze

Audio Content
mp3 file (470 KB)

burnt offering

In the Old Testament, a **burnt offering** is a form of sacrifice that people bring to God. When a person brings God a burnt offering, he kills an animal and burns this animal completely on an altar, which is a special place meant for bringing gifts to God. When a person brings God a burnt offering, they are saying to God: "Just as I am completely burning this animal, I am completely devoted to you."

burnt offering

Audio Content
mp3 file (344 KB)